

And we hope that people will see the benefits of closer collaboration with us over time and stop wasting resources by merging our code.

Q AOO has been a part of Google Summer of Code for the past eight years. Is there a reason for continuing this association year after year?

GSOC is a very good initiative that gives students the chance to do something really useful with their spare time over the summer holidays and to earn some money. For the mentoring organisation, it's always a good opportunity to bring some new talented developers onto the project. And, by the way, we didn't participate in all the past eight years. We participated the first three or four years as a standalone mentoring organisation but were not accepted in that role subsequently due to some problems that I'm not too sure about. During this time, we adapted the idea and ran our own OpenOffice internship programme, which was comparable.

"The biggest advantage of OpenOffice, from my perspective, is that it is open source and that the source code is available. The whole development is transparent and public for anybody who is interested. Anybody can help to improve the program and give something back. It doesn't have to be a code contribution."

This year, we participated again under Apache, as a mentoring organisation. I am happy to be a mentor again. GSOC gives students the opportunity to work on really huge projects and learn how communities work; they also get to know that they can participate in bigger open source projects.

Q Recently, the All India Council For Technical Education has made Microsoft Office 365 mandatory for students at all its approved technical institutes in India. This means millions of students are being forced to adopt Microsoft Office 365. What is your take on this issue?

Please correct me if I am wrong but I believe Microsoft has sponsored educational institutions for many years, which of course, is good. This kind of global decision can be due to several reasons and I can't comment on it. I believe in open standards and open source, and OpenOffice is both. If you want to use it, it is free for everybody, not only in the institutes but also at home or in any other place where office functionality is useful and necessary.

Q Please share what benefits OpenOffice offers over Microsoft's software.

The biggest advantage of OpenOffice, from my perspective, is that it is open source and that the source code is available. The whole development is transparent and public for anybody who is interested. Anybody can help to improve the program and give something back. It doesn't have to be a code contribution. It can be active participation in user forums, it can be documentation or help to do testing to ensure the overall quality of OpenOffice over time. Every single contribution to the project is useful and appreciated.

Q What changes has OpenOffice seen in the post-Oracle era?

OpenOffice is now under the umbrella of the well-known and globally accepted Apache Software Foundation (ASF). It is completely controlled by the project and its members, and not by a single big company. In the beginning, it was really confusing; we had to find our place inside Apache and that was indeed not easy for one of the biggest open source projects ever with a long history. We had to do a lot of things to keep the status quo and to preserve everything from earlier times. After this huge amount of work, we released the first version AOO 3.4 under Apache; that brought us into some calmer waters and we were able to concentrate on our real work and mission. Some people wanted to see us fail but we didn't, and OpenOffice is a healthy and growing project at its new home at the ASF.

The project is completely driven by its members with a truly flat hierarchy. No formal leaders govern the project and all members are equal. The people who do the work, drive the project—which is the true spirit of open source. Anybody can join and help to drive things forward. Nobody should expect others to do the work, but should instead start to think how they can contribute back to the project and help to make it better.

It's quite simple at Apache. You can propose what you want to do and if nobody complains, you just do it or start working on it. If there are complaints, discuss these first and arrive at a consensus on how to move forward. This works quite well, and we discuss the high level vision and product directions globally to get a common view on the future of our product.

Q How do you rate the contributions from India for the OpenOffice Project?

I see any contribution to the project as a positive, independent of where it comes from. We appreciate the contribution from Kadal Amutham, who completed the translation for Tamil. We would like to complete the translation for Hindi as soon as possible and volunteers are welcome to help. Currently, I am working with Rajath Shashidara, a student of BITS Pilani, on a GSOC project. I attended several events in India and met many of the enthusiastic and talented volunteers. We welcome everybody to our project and look forward to work with new volunteers. OpenOffice is so huge and there is enough work to do. The interesting part of such a huge open source project